

Psalms 119

Thy Word Have I Hid in Mine Heart

Thy word have I hid in mine heart, that I might not sin against thee

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Blessed are the undefiled in the way, who walk in the law of the LORD.*
- 2 *Blessed are they that keep his testimonies, and that seek him with the whole heart.*
- 3 *They also do no iniquity: they walk in his ways.*
- 4 *Thou hast commanded us to keep thy precepts diligently.*
- 5 *O that my ways were directed to keep thy statutes!*
- 6 *Then shall I not be ashamed, when I have respect unto all thy commandments.*
- 7 *I will praise thee with uprightness of heart, when I shall have learned thy righteous judgments.*
- 8 *I will keep thy statutes: O forsake me not utterly.*
- 9 *Wherewithal shall a young man cleanse his way? by taking heed thereto according to thy word.*
- 10 *With my whole heart have I sought thee: O let me not wander from thy commandments.*
- 11 *Thy word have I hid in mine heart, that I might not sin against thee.*
- 12 *Blessed art thou, O LORD: teach me thy statutes.*
- 13 *With my lips have I declared all the judgments of thy mouth.*
- 14 *I have rejoiced in the way of thy testimonies, as much as in all riches.*
- 15 *I will meditate in thy precepts, and have respect unto thy ways.*
- 16 *I will delight myself in thy statutes: I will not forget thy word.*
- 17 *Deal bountifully with thy servant, that I may live, and keep thy word.*
- 18 *Open thou mine eyes, that I may behold wondrous things out of thy law.*
- 19 *I am a stranger in the earth: hide not thy commandments from me.*
- 20 *My soul breaketh for the longing that it hath unto thy judgments at all times.*
- 21 *Thou hast rebuked the proud that are cursed, which do err from thy commandments.*
- 22 *Remove from me reproach and contempt; for I have kept thy testimonies.*
- 23 *Princes also did sit and speak against me: but thy servant did meditate in thy statutes.*
- 24 *Thy testimonies also are my delight and my counsellors.*
- 25 *My soul cleaveth unto the dust: quicken thou me according to thy word.*
- 26 *I have declared my ways, and thou heardest me: teach me thy statutes.*
- 27 *Make me to understand the way of thy precepts: so shall I talk of thy wondrous works.*
- 28 *My soul melteth for heaviness: strengthen thou me according unto thy word.*
- 29 *Remove from me the way of lying: and grant me thy law graciously.*
- 30 *I have chosen the way of truth: thy judgments have I laid before me.*
- 31 *I have stuck unto thy testimonies: O LORD, put me not to shame.*
- 32 *I will run the way of thy commandments, when thou shalt enlarge my heart.*
- 33 *Teach me, O LORD, the way of thy statutes; and I shall keep it unto the end.*
- 34 *Give me understanding, and I shall keep thy law; yea, I shall observe it with my whole heart.*
- 35 *Make me to go in the path of thy commandments; for therein do I delight.*
- 36 *Incline my heart unto thy testimonies, and not to covetousness.*
- 37 *Turn away mine eyes from beholding vanity; and quicken thou me in thy way.*
- 38 *Stablish thy word unto thy servant, who is devoted to thy fear.*
- 39 *Turn away my reproach which I fear: for thy judgments are good.*
- 40 *Behold, I have longed after thy precepts: quicken me in thy righteousness.*
- 41 *Let thy mercies come also unto me, O LORD, even thy salvation, according to thy word.*
- 42 *So shall I have wherewith to answer him that reproacheth me: for I trust in thy word.*

43 And take not the word of truth utterly out of my mouth; for I have hoped in thy judgments.
44 So shall I keep thy law continually for ever and ever.
45 And I will walk at liberty: for I seek thy precepts.
46 I will speak of thy testimonies also before kings, and will not be ashamed.
47 And I will delight myself in thy commandments, which I have loved.
48 My hands also will I lift up unto thy commandments, which I have loved; and I will meditate in thy statutes.
49 Remember the word unto thy servant, upon which thou hast caused me to hope.
50 This is my comfort in my affliction: for thy word hath quickened me.
51 The proud have had me greatly in derision: yet have I not declined from thy law.
52 I remembered thy judgments of old, O LORD; and have comforted myself.
53 Horror hath taken hold upon me because of the wicked that forsake thy law.
54 Thy statutes have been my songs in the house of my pilgrimage.
55 I have remembered thy name, O LORD, in the night, and have kept thy law.
56 This I had, because I kept thy precepts.
57 Thou art my portion, O LORD: I have said that I would keep thy words.
58 I intreated thy favour with my whole heart: be merciful unto me according to thy word.
59 I thought on my ways, and turned my feet unto thy testimonies.
60 I made haste, and delayed not to keep thy commandments.
61 The bands of the wicked have robbed me: but I have not forgotten thy law.
62 At midnight I will rise to give thanks unto thee because of thy righteous judgments.
63 I am a companion of all them that fear thee, and of them that keep thy precepts.
64 The earth, O LORD, is full of thy mercy: teach me thy statutes.
65 Thou hast dealt well with thy servant, O LORD, according unto thy word.
66 Teach me good judgment and knowledge: for I have believed thy commandments.
67 Before I was afflicted I went astray: but now have I kept thy word.
68 Thou art good, and doest good; teach me thy statutes.
69 The proud have forged a lie against me: but I will keep thy precepts with my whole heart.
70 Their heart is as fat as grease; but I delight in thy law.
71 It is good for me that I have been afflicted; that I might learn thy statutes.
72 The law of thy mouth is better unto me than thousands of gold and silver.
73 Thy hands have made me and fashioned me: give me understanding, that I may learn thy commandments.
74 They that fear thee will be glad when they see me; because I have hoped in thy word.
75 I know, O LORD, that thy judgments are right, and that thou in faithfulness hast afflicted me.
76 Let, I pray thee, thy merciful kindness be for my comfort, according to thy word unto thy servant.
77 Let thy tender mercies come unto me, that I may live: for thy law is my delight.
78 Let the proud be ashamed; for they dealt perversely with me without a cause: but I will meditate in thy precepts.
79 Let those that fear thee turn unto me, and those that have known thy testimonies.
80 Let my heart be sound in thy statutes; that I be not ashamed.
81 My soul fainteth for thy salvation: but I hope in thy word.
82 Mine eyes fail for thy word, saying, When wilt thou comfort me?
83 For I am become like a bottle in the smoke; yet do I not forget thy statutes.
84 How many are the days of thy servant? when wilt thou execute judgment on them that persecute me?
85 The proud have digged pits for me, which are not after thy law.
86 All thy commandments are faithful: they persecute me wrongfully; help thou me.
87 They had almost consumed me upon earth; but I forsook not thy precepts.
88 Quicken me after thy lovingkindness; so shall I keep the testimony of thy mouth.
89 For ever, O LORD, thy word is settled in heaven.
90 Thy faithfulness is unto all generations: thou hast established the earth, and it abideth.
91 They continue this day according to thine ordinances: for all are thy servants.
92 Unless thy law had been my delights, I should then have perished in mine affliction.

93 *I will never forget thy precepts: for with them thou hast quickened me.*
94 *I am thine, save me; for I have sought thy precepts.*
95 *The wicked have waited for me to destroy me: but I will consider thy testimonies.*
96 *I have seen an end of all perfection: but thy commandment is exceeding broad.*
97 *O how love I thy law! it is my meditation all the day.*
98 *Thou through thy commandments hast made me wiser than mine enemies: for they are ever with me.*
99 *I have more understanding than all my teachers: for thy testimonies are my meditation.*
100 *I understand more than the ancients, because I keep thy precepts.*
101 *I have refrained my feet from every evil way, that I might keep thy word.*
102 *I have not departed from thy judgments: for thou hast taught me.*
103 *How sweet are thy words unto my taste! yea, sweeter than honey to my mouth!*
104 *Through thy precepts I get understanding: therefore I hate every false way.*
105 *Thy word is a lamp unto my feet, and a light unto my path.*
106 *I have sworn, and I will perform it, that I will keep thy righteous judgments.*
107 *I am afflicted very much: quicken me, O LORD, according unto thy word.*
108 *Accept, I beseech thee, the freewill offerings of my mouth, O LORD, and teach me thy judgments.*
109 *My soul is continually in my hand: yet do I not forget thy law.*
110 *The wicked have laid a snare for me: yet I erred not from thy precepts.*
111 *Thy testimonies have I taken as an heritage for ever: for they are the rejoicing of my heart.*
112 *I have inclined mine heart to perform thy statutes alway, even unto the end.*
113 *I hate vain thoughts: but thy law do I love.*
114 *Thou art my hiding place and my shield: I hope in thy word.*
115 *Depart from me, ye evildoers: for I will keep the commandments of my God.*
116 *Uphold me according unto thy word, that I may live: and let me not be ashamed of my hope.*
117 *Hold thou me up, and I shall be safe: and I will have respect unto thy statutes continually.*
118 *Thou hast trodden down all them that err from thy statutes: for their deceit is falsehood.*
119 *Thou puttest away all the wicked of the earth like dross: therefore I love thy testimonies.*
120 *My flesh trembleth for fear of thee; and I am afraid of thy judgments.*
121 *I have done judgment and justice: leave me not to mine oppressors.*
122 *Be surety for thy servant for good: let not the proud oppress me.*
123 *Mine eyes fail for thy salvation, and for the word of thy righteousness.*
124 *Deal with thy servant according unto thy mercy, and teach me thy statutes.*
125 *I am thy servant; give me understanding, that I may know thy testimonies.*
126 *It is time for thee, LORD, to work: for they have made void thy law.*
127 *Therefore I love thy commandments above gold; yea, above fine gold.*
128 *Therefore I esteem all thy precepts concerning all things to be right; and I hate every false way.*
129 *Thy testimonies are wonderful: therefore doth my soul keep them.*
130 *The entrance of thy words giveth light; it giveth understanding unto the simple.*
131 *I opened my mouth, and panted: for I longed for thy commandments.*
132 *Look thou upon me, and be merciful unto me, as thou usest to do unto those that love thy name.*
133 *Order my steps in thy word: and let not any iniquity have dominion over me.*
134 *Deliver me from the oppression of man: so will I keep thy precepts.*
135 *Make thy face to shine upon thy servant; and teach me thy statutes.*
136 *Rivers of waters run down mine eyes, because they keep not thy law.*
137 *Righteous art thou, O LORD, and upright are thy judgments.*
138 *Thy testimonies that thou hast commanded are righteous and very faithful.*
139 *My zeal hath consumed me, because mine enemies have forgotten thy words.*
140 *Thy word is very pure: therefore thy servant loveth it.*
141 *I am small and despised: yet do not I forget thy precepts.*
142 *Thy righteousness is an everlasting righteousness, and thy law is the truth.*

143 *Trouble and anguish have taken hold on me: yet thy commandments are my delights.*
144 *The righteousness of thy testimonies is everlasting: give me understanding, and I shall live.*
145 *I cried with my whole heart; hear me, O LORD: I will keep thy statutes.*
146 *I cried unto thee; save me, and I shall keep thy testimonies.*
147 *I prevented the dawning of the morning, and cried: I hoped in thy word.*
148 *Mine eyes prevent the night watches, that I might meditate in thy word.*
149 *Hear my voice according unto thy lovingkindness: O LORD, quicken me according to thy judgment.*
150 *They draw nigh that follow after mischief: they are far from thy law.*
151 *Thou art near, O LORD; and all thy commandments are truth.*
152 *Concerning thy testimonies, I have known of old that thou hast founded them for ever.*
153 *Consider mine affliction, and deliver me: for I do not forget thy law.*
154 *Plead my cause, and deliver me: quicken me according to thy word.*
155 *Salvation is far from the wicked: for they seek not thy statutes.*
156 *Great are thy tender mercies, O LORD: quicken me according to thy judgments.*
157 *Many are my persecutors and mine enemies; yet do I not decline from thy testimonies.*
158 *I beheld the transgressors, and was grieved; because they kept not thy word.*
159 *Consider how I love thy precepts: quicken me, O LORD, according to thy lovingkindness.*
160 *Thy word is true from the beginning: and every one of thy righteous judgments endureth for ever.*
161 *Princes have persecuted me without a cause: but my heart standeth in awe of thy word.*
162 *I rejoice at thy word, as one that findeth great spoil.*
163 *I hate and abhor lying: but thy law do I love.*
164 *Seven times a day do I praise thee because of thy righteous judgments.*
165 *Great peace have they which love thy law: and nothing shall offend them.*
166 *LORD, I have hoped for thy salvation, and done thy commandments.*
167 *My soul hath kept thy testimonies; and I love them exceedingly.*
168 *I have kept thy precepts and thy testimonies: for all my ways are before thee.*
169 *Let my cry come near before thee, O LORD: give me understanding according to thy word.*
170 *Let my supplication come before thee: deliver me according to thy word.*
171 *My lips shall utter praise, when thou hast taught me thy statutes.*
172 *My tongue shall speak of thy word: for all thy commandments are righteousness.*
173 *Let thine hand help me; for I have chosen thy precepts.*
174 *I have longed for thy salvation, O LORD; and thy law is my delight.*
175 *Let my soul live, and it shall praise thee; and let thy judgments help me.*
176 *I have gone astray like a lost sheep; seek thy servant; for I do not forget thy commandments.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 119 is by far the longest chapter in the Bible, an elaborate acrostic of twenty-two eight-verse sections, one for each letter of the Hebrew alphabet, in which nearly every line names some aspect of God's word—law, testimonies, statutes, commandments, judgments, precepts, word, ways. Henry reads its sheer length and structure as deliberate: a whole alphabet devoted to a single subject, modeling exhaustive, unhurried meditation rather than a quick devotional glance. MacArthur-style notes highlight that the psalm was likely composed during real affliction (its author repeatedly mentions persecution, mockery, and near-death trouble), so that its praise of God's word is not naive but forged specifically under pressure.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-8

Aleph. The psalm opens by naming blessedness for those whose way is blameless, who walk in the Lord's law and keep His testimonies, seeking Him with the whole heart rather than half-attention. A personal request follows almost immediately—that God would direct the psalmist's own ways to keep His statutes—admitting the desire is genuine but not yet fully realized.

Verse 9-16

Beth. A young man's need to cleanse his way is answered directly: by taking heed according to God's word, sought with the whole heart to avoid wandering from His commandments. The word is hidden in the heart specifically to prevent sin, and the psalmist

commits to rehearsing God's statutes with his lips and delighting in His testimonies as in great riches.

Verse 17-24

Gimel. A plea to deal bountifully so that the psalmist may live and keep God's word is paired with a request to open his eyes to see wondrous things out of the law. Confessing himself a stranger and sojourner on earth, he asks that commandments not be hidden from him, even while princes sit and speak against him—persecution met by continued meditation on God's statutes as his counselors.

Verse 25-32

Daleth. The psalmist's soul cleaves to the dust, and he asks to be quickened according to God's word; heaviness of soul is met by a request for strengthening according to that same word. Having chosen the way of truth and set God's judgments before him, he asks not to be put to shame, promising to run in the way of God's commandments once his heart is enlarged.

Verse 33-40

He. Four requests for instruction open the section: teach me, give me understanding, make me go in the path of Your commandments, incline my heart to Your testimonies rather than to covetousness. Turning away his eyes from vanity and establishing God's word are both asked for, along with removal of reproach and rebuke, since he has hoped in God's judgments.

Verse 41-48

Vav. Mercy and salvation according to God's word are asked for specifically so that he might have an answer for those who reproach him, trusting in that word. He resolves to keep God's law continually, speak of His testimonies before kings without shame, and delight himself in commandments he loves, lifting up his hands toward them.

Verse 49-56

Zayin. God's word to His servant is asked to be remembered, since it has been his hope and comfort in affliction, even while the proud mock him excessively without turning him from God's law. Remembering God's judgments of old comforts him, even as indignation rises against those who have forsaken the law, and God's statutes become songs in his time of sojourning.

Verse 57-64

Heth. The Lord is named directly as his portion, prompting a promise to keep His words and to seek His favor with his whole heart. Considering his own ways, he turns his feet to God's testimonies, making haste rather than delaying to keep His commandments, and asks to be a companion of all who fear the Lord and keep His precepts.

Verse 65-72

Teth. God's good dealing with His servant is affirmed, followed by a request for good judgment and knowledge because he has believed God's commandments. A striking admission follows: before he was afflicted he went astray, but now he keeps God's word, affirming that the affliction itself has been good for him, teaching statutes better than the law of gold and silver could.

Verse 73-80

Yod. God's hands having made and fashioned him grounds a request for understanding to learn His commandments; those who fear God are asked to see him and be glad, because he has hoped in God's word. Even in affliction, acknowledged as deserved and faithful correction, he asks for tender mercies and that his heart be sound in God's statutes so he is not put to shame.

Verse 81-88

Kaph. His soul faints for God's salvation, his eyes fail waiting for God's word, and he asks how long until judgment is executed on his persecutors—weariness and honest impatience voiced directly. Nearly consumed on earth by those who have dug pits for him, he affirms he has not forsaken God's precepts, asking to be quickened according to God's lovingkindness.

Verse 89-96

Lamed. God's word is declared settled forever in heaven, His faithfulness reaching every generation, His ordinances establishing the earth itself which still stands as His servants. Had God's law not been his delight, he confesses he would have perished in his affliction; he will never forget precepts that have given him life.

Verse 97-104

Mem. Love for God's law is declared directly—meditated on all day—making him wiser than his enemies, giving more understanding than his teachers and the aged, because he keeps God's testimonies and precepts. Restraining his feet from every evil way in order to keep God's word, he finds God's judgments so sweet that he hates every false way.

Verse 105-112

Nun. God's word is called a lamp to his feet and light to his path, and he has sworn, with sworn resolve kept, to keep God's righteous judgments. Greatly afflicted, taking his life continually in his hand amid snares set by the wicked, he does not stray from God's precepts, having taken His testimonies as a heritage forever, his heart set to perform God's statutes to the very end.

Verse 113-120

Samekh. Vain thoughts are hated, but God's law is loved; God is named a hiding place and shield, and hope is placed specifically in His word. The wicked are asked to depart, and God is asked to hold him up and uphold him, while all who stray from His statutes,

however numerous, are set aside like dross, God's testimonies still loved despite his own awe at God's judgments.

Verse 121-128

Ayin. Having done judgment and justice, he asks not to be left to his oppressors, pleading for surety on his own behalf against the proud. His eyes fail waiting for God's salvation and righteous word, asking to be dealt with according to mercy and taught God's statutes, since it is time for the Lord to act when others have made His law void—prompting a love for God's commandments above gold and fine gold.

Verse 129-136

Pe. God's testimonies are called wonderful, and the entrance of His words gives light, giving understanding even to the simple. Panting with longing for God's commandments, he asks his steps be ordered by God's word and that no iniquity have dominion over him, his eyes running with rivers of tears because others do not keep God's law.

Verse 137-144

Tsadhe. God is declared righteous and His judgments upright, His testimonies very righteous and faithful; zeal consumes him because his enemies have forgotten God's words. Though small and despised, and though trouble and anguish have taken hold, God's commandments remain his delights, everlasting righteousness he asks understanding of in order to live.

Verse 145-152

Qoph. Crying with his whole heart, he asks to be heard and saved, keeping God's testimonies; rising before dawn and crying for help, he hopes in God's word, his eyes anticipating the night watches to meditate on it. Those drawing near with mischief are far from God's law, yet the Lord is near, His testimonies founded of old and forever.

Verse 153-160

Resh. Affliction is brought before God with a plea for deliverance, since he has not forgotten God's law; his cause is pleaded and he asks to be quickened according to God's word. Salvation, he observes, is far from the wicked because they do not seek God's statutes, while God's tender mercies are great and His word true from the very beginning.

Verse 161-168

Shin. Princes persecute him without cause, yet his heart stands in awe of God's word rather than of them, rejoicing in it like someone who has found great treasure. Hating and abhorring lying, he loves God's law, praising Him seven times a day for righteous judgments, with great peace belonging to those who love that law and nothing able to offend them.

Verse 169-176

Taw. A final concentrated plea closes the psalm: let his cry come near, give him understanding, let his supplication come before God, deliver him according to God's word. His lips are asked to pour forth praise once taught God's statutes, his tongue to speak of God's word, his hand held out for help—closing with a strikingly humble admission that he has gone astray like a lost sheep, asking God to seek His servant, since he has not forgotten God's commandments.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

An entire alphabet devoted to a single subject models what unhurried, exhaustive meditation on God's word actually looks like—not a quick glance for comfort, but sustained attention that returns to the same truths from every angle, under real affliction, persecution, and honest impatience. The psalmist's love for God's word is forged specifically under pressure, not despite it, and the psalm's own closing image—a sheep gone astray, still asking to be sought—refuses to let all this devotion curdle into self-sufficient pride.

Application for life today.

Choose one section of this psalm and actually practice its acrostic discipline: spend unhurried time meditating on a single truth from God's word today rather than moving quickly past it. Notice how often affliction and persecution appear alongside declarations of love for God's word (vv. 71, 75, 92, 143, 153)—let that reshape any assumption that hardship and delight in Scripture are incompatible. Take the psalm's final verse personally: however much devotion you have practiced, come to God still as a sheep gone astray asking to be sought, not as someone who has arrived.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What would it look like to practice this psalm's own discipline this week—choosing one truth from God's word and returning to it slowly and repeatedly, rather than moving on quickly?

2. How does the psalmist's repeated pairing of affliction with deepened love for God's word (vv. 71, 92, 143) challenge any assumption you hold that hardship and delight in Scripture cannot coexist?

3. The psalm closes with the humble image of a lost sheep still asking to be sought (v. 176)—where do you need that same posture, rather than resting on your own record of devotion?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).